rested in the dead of night on the charge of "giving false information to the media". When produced in court, he couldn't walk without assistance. It was clear he'd been tortured. Denied bail five times, he was in jail for 107 days.

Even though Section 57 of Bangladesh's Information and Communication Technology Act—the law under which Alam had been charged—has been repealed, the activist still faces a potential 14 years in prison. Asked if the possibility leaves him afraid, Alam says, "It would be naive not to be wary, but in battle, fear is something you learn to live with." To avoid being tracked, Alam has now stopped using a mobile phone: "My security, and that of my family, friends and colleagues is always a concern."

Looking back, however, Alam says, "I can now see life through a different lens, which provides an insight I might otherwise never have had. As for the ill treatment, I'm alive. I am still physically and mentally able. I have food on my table. That is more than many others in my country can claim. My nation is suffering far more than I ever did." Alam, it seems obvious, will not go silently into any night.

By not buckling, Alam is also setting an example. Having founded the Drik Picture Library in 1989 and the Pathshala South Asian Media Institute in 1998, Alam has, over the years, recruited several young "warriors" to fight the good fight. "A teacher's job is to open windows to people's minds. Once you teach people to see, you must have things to show. The lifestyle one leads is the finest teaching tool available." Rather than dwell on the distinction between aperture and shutter speeds, Alam's lessons can also be pithy: "Changing the world for the better is what it is all about. Depicting it is a by-product." ■

– Shreevatsa Nevatia

BOOKS

IN THE EYE OF THE STORM

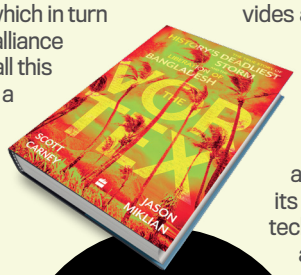
The Vortex is a riveting retelling of the story of Bangladesh's liberation

Multiple arcs of crises intersected in the eastern half of the Bengal Delta in 1970-71 and changed the status of East Pakistan to Bangladesh. The first was the maturing of a political and federal crisis due to Pakistan's discrimination against and exploitation of Bengalis. Post 1947, East Pakistan became in many ways a colony of the western wing. The second was a geopolitical crisis that followed when Pakistan became an intermediary in cementing a US-China *entente*, a development which India and the Soviet Union viewed as an alliance of all three, which in turn led them to forge an alliance of their own. Finally, all this was underwritten by a climatic catastrophic in the form of cyclone Bhola with disastrous consequences for deltaic East Bengal.

This story of the emergence of Bangladesh is well known. *The Vortex*, however, provides a gripping retelling of these three principal themes: the politics, the geopolitics and the cyclone, populated by both known and unknown actors—West Pakistanis, Bengalis and Americans. Readers here may well find India's role unusually diminished, but this does not detract from *Vortex*'s fast-paced narrative. How the cyclone and later the genocide in East Pakistan became international causes are particularly compelling narratives.

The dramatic element, in an already drama-filled history, is enhanced by a creative conjuring of "motivations and states of mind that are not preserved in the historical record". This means splicing disparate situations and facts, combining events and situations that may not have happened together and occasionally extrapolating conversations. The purist may cavil but the end result is a riveting read in which the considerable research and interviews the authors have pursued give a granular feel of what happened half a century ago.

The creation of Bangladesh is also a story of Pakistan's colossal misjudgments and the character flaws of its leadership, particularly its military dictator, General Yahya Khan. His carousing and philandering, combined with the narcissism of being a global actor sharing the stage with Nixon and Mao, provides a near morality tale of how power corrupts and depraves. However, the reader may wonder whether *Vortex* assumes too much in its quest for historical technicolor: for instance, a scene when the Shah of Iran on a state visit to Pakistan pounds on Yahya's bedroom door and interrupts him with his mistress. Undoubtedly, in post 1971, there were many Pakistanis who implicitly believed such a story.



THE VORTEX: The True Story of History's Deadliest Storm and the Liberation of Bangladesh
by Scott Carney and Jason Miklian
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹599; 528 pages

Over time, the revulsion for Yahya and the belief that it was the depravity of their rulers alone that broke up Pakistan, has kept the story credible. Even so, while such devices may make a rollicking yarn, they surely stretch credibility to maintain that Yahya finally signed off on the air strikes against India and initiated the 1971 war out of frustration and anger because—according to the authors of *Vortex*—he'd just confronted his son *in flagrante delicto* with a favourite mistress! Nevertheless, a thunderingly good read. ■

–T.C.A. Raghavan
(The writer is a former High Commissioner to Pakistan)